LOCAL GOVERNMENT

Fort Worth prepares to welcome MedStar work-force into fire department, union

by Cody Wolf
January 6, 2026 4:00 pm

Members of IAFF 440 and the city of Fort Worth participated in a bargaining team meet-and-confer bargaining session Oct. 9, 2024, at the Local 440 Jim Tate Building. (Courtesy Photo | Fort Worth Report)

Sign up for unwarned news for the Fort Worth area. Delivered to your inbox — completely free.

Last May, Fort Worth City Council members unanimously approved a plan to dissolve the region's longtime EMS provider, MedStar. The city opted to switch to a Fort Worth-based EMS system, housed within its fire department.

That decision necessitated a lot of behind-the-scenes work to make a fire-based system feasible, including expansing collective bargaining between the city and the union representing its firefighters, IAFF Local 440. The majority of MedStar employees have been mapped over to equivalent positions with the city, in an effort to retain talent during the merger.

The city and IAFF 440 have been bargaining over the details of that merger since July 2024. They hashed multiple bargaining sessions, where city management sat across the table from the union's board, and convened in executive session subcommittees dedicated to hashing out the essential details.

Key topics included which incoming MedStar employees should receive civil service protection; what their pay structures should look like; and how to handle distribution of accrued vacation time and seniority. Representatives from the city, the union, and MedStar participated.

"We talked a lot about culture," Assistant City Manager Valerie Washington said in an interview with the Report. "You have this new workforce, and you don't want to make them feel less than the current workforce [firefighters]. We did everything we could to preserve and mitigate that feeling."

In a Jan. 14 work session, Washington briefed council members on the progress that has been made up to this point, and presented a draft agreement that the City Council will vote on Jan. 28. The agreement includes an extension of Kya million over 15 months, costs that include around 65 new IAFF positions on 24-hour shifts and nine new ambulances.

Among the provisions in the agreement are an average 10% salary increase for incoming MedStar EMTs and paramedics, the creation of new EMS job classifications; and civil service representation for both EMTs, paramedics and EMS telecommunicators.

"Our two main driving ideals were to serve the citizens better and then take great care of those people as they come over and become part of our team," Zac Shaffer, president of IAFF 440, said.

Civil service protections weren't always guaranteed for telecommunicators. Early in the bargaining process, the city proposed excluding them from the bargaining group and instead classifying them as general employees. The fire union pushed back strongly on the suggestion, and the city's bargaining team eventually reconsidered and agreed to civil service classifications for telecommunicators as well.

Shaffer noted that the fire department is the only department whose telecommunicators are currently in the civil service. The Fort Worth Police department's telecommunicators are considered general employees. The police department has had persistent problems with call center staffing, an issue Shaffer attributes in part to a lack of civil service protections.

"We think the best way to keep those call rooms full, is to make sure that they're compensated well and they have a right to their job," Shaffer said.

What is civil service?

In the city of Fort Worth, both police officers and firefighters are sworn civil service positions. In a civil service system, hiring is conducted through examinations, and promotion is determined through a step process. Sworn employees have protections rights to their jobs and representation through their department's union. IAFF 440 represents Fort Worth firefighters, Civil service for police officers and firefighters in Texas is implemented by Chapter 143 of the Texas Local Government Code.

'Get them on an equal playing field'

Holly Moyer, the city's assistant human resources director, was part of the city's shift in mindset with regard to telecommunicators. Before she joined the city of Fort Worth in 2022, she had extensive experience working with fire and EMS divisions in central Texas, which gave her an experienced perspective on the issue.

She referenced the working of local government code Chapter 142, which specifies that a fire department employee whose primary duties are to provide emergency medical services is entitled to civil service protection.

"That is what the telecommunicators are doing," Moyer said. "They're on the 911 phone, and they're providing that service until the EMT and paramedics get to the patient. So that's just something I think was a factor in that decision-making process."

Dianna Giordano, the city's human resources director, said another big part of this process has been communicating the benefits of civil service protection to MedStar employees. MedStar employees have not previously had civil service representation, and Giordano said there are unique benefits to being civil service employees, including guaranteed step pay increases and exam-based entry and promotional opportunities.

"It removes those individual influences from hiring and promotion so that it's a very systematic process," she said. "We're trying to communicate that as much as possible."

Shaffer said IAFF 440 has had similar conversations with MedStar employees throughout the bargaining process. MedStar employees were invited to the bargaining sessions, and several sat in on the proceedings throughout the year.

"They don't really know us, right? They didn't elect me. They didn't elect my board," he said. "I think that's a huge change for them and it's been a huge change for us. So we're just trying to get them on an equal playing field."

He's also had conversations with firefighters who'd seen the merger non-warmly. Many firefighters joined the Fort Worth Fire Department because it didn't run an ambulance service, he said, and worried that dissolving MedStar would change that.

"They thought this might mean that they're gonna all of a sudden be riding an ambulance full time," he said. "And the way that we're able to take care of the MedStar people is we're bringing them over. I think that's gonna be still have an available workforce to staff those ambulances."

'It's history in the making'

Giordano said she hasn't seen this kind of merger in many other major cities, and Fort Worth is acting as a trailblazer while it maps the future of its new EMS system.

"It's a huge task," she said. "It's a huge undertaking. It's history in the making."

There's plenty of work left to do after the council approves the agreement. The city's HR team has tapped a consultant to help work through any friction while merging the workforce of MedStar and the Fort Worth Fire Department, a project that will run throughout the year.

MedStar has served more than a dozen Tarrant County cities and over a million residents as the sole EMS provider for North Texas. The city is now issuing out a subscription-based model of service for the other cities that previously relied on MedStar.

"And we don't have an EMS budget in place for the city of Fort Worth yet," Washington said. "So we will be going to the mayor and council in the spring to set up the fourth-quarter budget for EMS."

Shaffer's team is also hard at work figuring out logistics ahead of the merger, which is expected to take full effect in July. Deployment models, infrastructure and scheduling are top of mind.

"We've got about 100 working days between now and July 1," he said. "And we have our work cut out for us. But you know, I'm getting the team in place and then saying, 'Hey, listen, here's what we need, here's what it will cost, and here's our timeline for getting it finished and wrapped up and ready to go."

Related

Fort Worth Report is certified by the Journalism Trust Initiative for adhering to standards for ethical journalism.

Republish This Story

CC BY ND

Republishing is free for noncommercial entities. Commercial entities are prohibited without a licensing agreement. Contact us for details.

TAGGED:
Collective bargaining
emergency medical services
fire-based EMS
Fort Worth Fire Department
IAFF 440
MedStar

CODY WOLF
Government Accountability Reporter

Emily Wolf was a local government accountability reporter for the Fort Worth Report. Originally from Round Rock, Texas, she spent several years at the University of Missouri's Columbia journalism investigative... More by Cody Wolf

Search...

Send us a story tip

MOST POPULAR

City Council approves up to $200K for Fort Worth's first Vietnam War monument

Fort Worth's DOI wants more community input on its data. Here's how you can help

Nearly 1,000 acre-feet of water lost from Fort Worth's Lake Worth

More than 450 cottage-style homes headed for parts of east, south Fort Worth

Flight over Fort Worth high-speed rail corridor ends in crash; initial finding cites could affect property

Arlington's growing population, transition drive demand for new cell towers

Arlington shooting center crowds new park, amenities in first phase of Viridian development

Rail expansion expected to link Fort Worth's TEXrail with Dallas, Denton systems

Tuition at many Fort Worth private schools is higher than proposed — updated

More than 40 cottage-style homes headed for parts of east, south Fort Worth

Annual arts festival returns to downtown Fort Worth this weekend. Here's a limited article

FWR
FORT WORTH REPORT

MAILING ADDRESS: P.O. Box 50378, Fort Worth, TX 76105
PHONE: 817.405.1030
EMAIL: hello@fortworthreport.org

NEWSLETTERS
DONATE
Media Kit
Contact Us
Privacy Policy

Our Mission:
The Report exists to produce high-quality objective local journalism that informs public decision-making, addresses the quality of life of our community's citizens, holds our policymakers accountable, and serves as a neutral convener by bringing them and making sure they are valued and understood. It all adds up to a community that is better informed and more prosperous. Our reporting will be free to all who access our work, regardless of their ability to pay.

THIS SITE IS PROTECTED BY RECAPTCHA AND THE GOOGLE PRIVACY POLICY AND TERMS OF SERVICE APPLY.

© 2025 FORT WORTH REPORT
POWERED BY WORDPRESS VIP